



THE
**SANDWICH
PROJECT**

www.TheSandwichProject.org

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TSP HOST HANDBOOK

Nourish the Hungry. Feed the Soul.



Welcome to The Sandwich Project

Thank you for volunteering with The Sandwich Project (TSP). Whether you're making sandwiches, hosting a collection site, or delivering meals, you play a critical role in helping us feed our community with dignity and care.

This handbook provides the food safety guidelines and role-specific procedures that every TSP volunteer needs. It's organized in two parts: first, the food safety principles that apply to everyone and explain why we do what we do; then, step-by-step instructions for your specific role.

Who We Serve

People who are unhoused or housing-insecure, children and students, veterans, seniors, and working individuals and families who may be struggling to afford enough food. Many of the people we serve also face additional challenges, such as health conditions, disabilities, limited access to transportation, and no healthcare insurance.



Our Volunteer Roles

We believe in the power of community, and each volunteer role is essential to our mission of feeding families with dignity.

Sandwich Makers

Prepare fresh, safe sandwiches following food safety protocols.

Hosts

Provide a central collection point for sandwich drop-offs and coordinate with drivers.

Drivers

Transport sandwiches from host homes to distribution partners.

Food Safety for All Volunteers

These food safety principles apply to every TSP volunteer—sandwich makers, hosts, and drivers alike. Understanding the reasoning behind our protocols will help you make smart decisions at every step, even when a situation isn't covered by a specific rule.

Why Food Safety Matters More for TSP

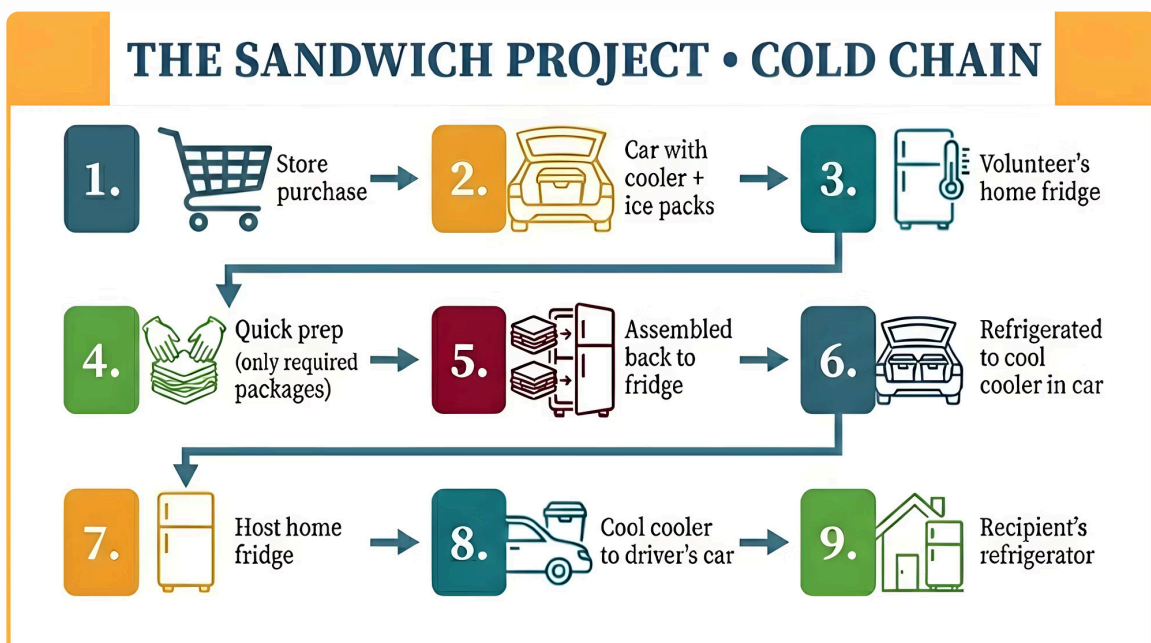
As an organization, we are subject to food safety laws. Our recipients—children, seniors, people who are sick or immunocompromised—are more vulnerable to foodborne illness than the average population, and many have limited access to healthcare.

For this reason, we hold ourselves to a higher standard than what you might apply in your own kitchen.

The Cold Chain

The "cold chain" means keeping perishable food consistently cold—below 39°F—from the moment it is purchased until it reaches the recipient organization. Every link in the chain matters: store to car, car to fridge, fridge to sandwich prep, back to fridge, fridge to cooler, cooler to delivery.

If any link breaks, we cannot guarantee the food is safe, even if it "looks fine." The cold chain is maintained by every volunteer across every role. Sandwich makers maintain it during shopping and prep. Hosts maintain it during collection and storage. Drivers maintain it during transport.



Food Safety: The Two-Hour Rule

When in Doubt, Throw It Out

Deli meat and cheese may only be above 39°F for a total of two hours, cumulatively. This is NOT two hours at a time—the time adds up across the entire process from factory to consumer.

- Re-cooling does NOT kill bacteria that have already grown.
- If food has been above 39°F for a total of two hours, it must be discarded.
- When in doubt, throw it out.

Absolute Temperature Limits

39°F (4°C)

This is the highest safe temperature for deli meat and cheese. Above this temperature, bacterial growth begins.

80°F (27°C)

Deli meat must never reach this temperature.

The Legal Standard

Perishable foods (deli meat/cheese) must stay below 39°F (4°C).

After 2 hours altogether above that, bacteria reach unsafe levels.

Re-cooling does not kill the bacteria that have already grown.

Why It Matters Even More

As an organization, we are subject to food safety laws.

Our recipients are more vulnerable to foodborne illness than the average population. For this reason, we must keep sandwiches and ingredients out of refrigeration for as little time as possible.



Critical: TSP serves children, seniors, people who are sick or immunocompromised, and others at higher risk of foodborne illness, many of whom have limited access to healthcare.

Food Safety: Refrigeration

Temperature Range

Refrigerators must consistently maintain a temperature between **34°–38°F**.

Air Circulation

Adequate air circulation is essential for the refrigerator to actually cool its contents. Do not block fans.

Never Overfill

Overfilled refrigerators can compromise airflow and create warm spots, compromising food safety.

Door Discipline

Refrigeration should remain closed at all times except for brief access to add or remove sandwiches or ingredients, as temperatures rise quickly, especially in hot weather.

Freezer Use

To make sandwiches extra cold for hot-weather distribution, the freezer may be used briefly—limit to 15–20 minutes.

Storage Best Practices

- Keep sandwiches organized by type (PB&J separate from Deli)
- Ensure all items are properly labeled before refrigerating
- Monitor refrigerator temperature regularly
- Remove personal food items to maximize space for TSP sandwiches



Cooler Safety Protocols

Coolers Are Not Refrigerators

Coolers keep cold food cold—coolers do not cool warm food. They preserve cold temperatures but do not lower them.

Unlike coolers, **refrigerators** actively circulate cold air to lower food temperatures.



Food Safety: Coolers & Transport

Coolers Work For:

Getting sandwich ingredients home from the grocery store.

Transporting pre-chilled sandwiches packed tightly with ice packs.

Properly packed coolers can maintain safe temperatures for up to one hour during active transport.

Coolers DO NOT Work For:

Bringing the temperature of **warm food** down.

Storing cold food for **long periods of time**.

Making warm food **safe again** by **recooling**.

Maximizing Cooler Performance & Safe Transport

Pack quickly

To keep warm air out, coolers should be packed quickly and closed between trips to the refrigerator for loaves. Keep your cooler in the shade while packing, too!

Plenty of Ice Packs in Contact with All Sandwiches

Place ice packs/sheets between layers of sandwiches and on top before closing the lid.

Pack Full with Minimal Free Space

Coolers with minimal air space stay colder longer than partially filled ones.

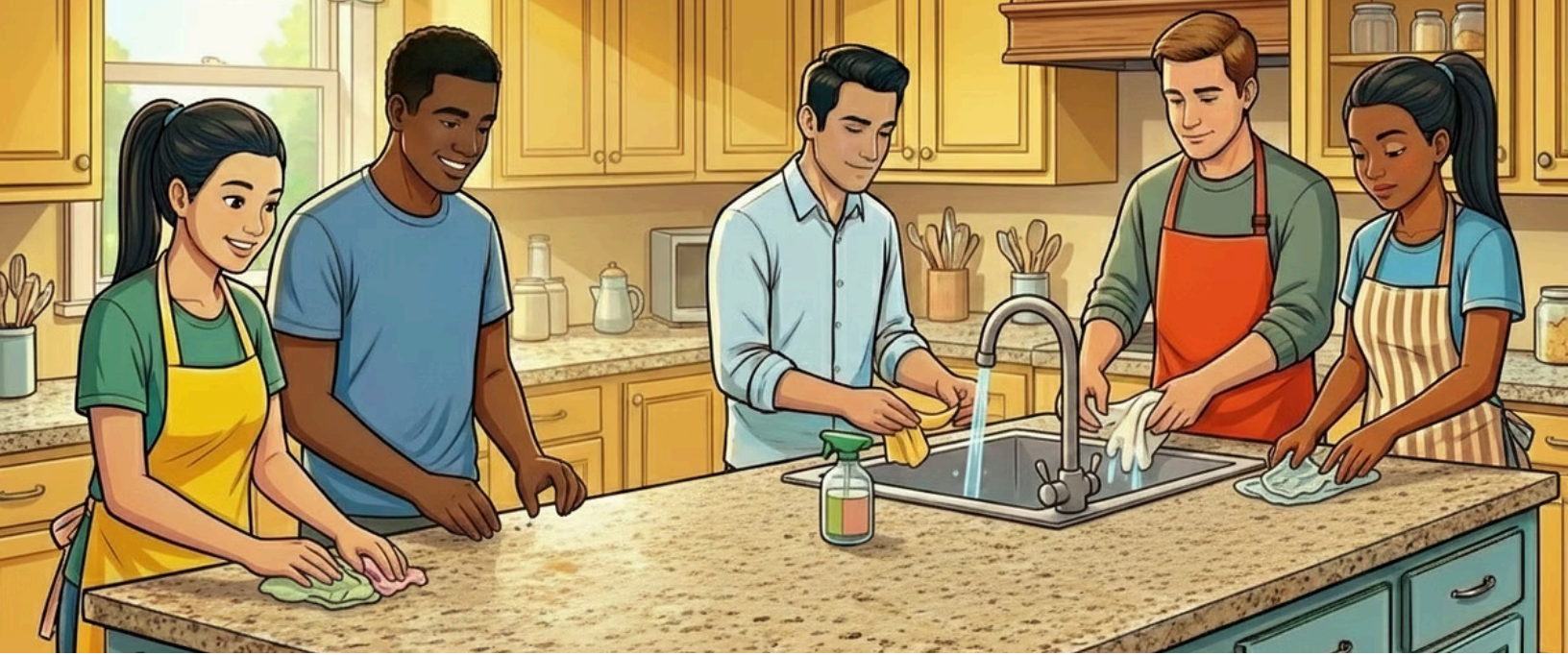
Keep Lid Closed Tightly

Every time you open a cooler, warm air enters. Do not open coolers during transport.

Critical Transport Safety

No Coolers in the Trunk

Keep coolers in the vehicle cabin where A/C circulates, never in the trunk, which lacks airflow and heats up quickly. Trunks can reach extreme temperatures, creating a high-risk environment for perishable food.



Food Safety: Sandwich Prep/Assembly

Clean Surfaces

Clean counters and wash utensils. Store personal items out of reach. Cover your table/counter with a disposable tablecloth for easy cleanup.

Handwashing

Wash hands with soap and water before starting prep work, during as necessary, and after all prep work is complete in preparation for sandwich making.

Hand sanitizer is unsafe for food handling, as alcohol residue can transfer to gloves and food, and it does not remove all bacteria, food residue, or contaminants.

Hair Restraint

Tie back hair (including bangs) or use a hairnet; use beard nets for facial hair. Do this before handwashing.

Food-Safe Gloves

After surfaces and hands are clean and hair is restrained, put on **food-safe gloves**, and do not touch anything other than food ingredients. Change gloves after touching anything other than your sandwich ingredients.

Food Safety: Hygiene Standards

Coolers

Wash coolers with soap and warm water after use.

Allow coolers to fully air-dry before storing. Once dry, cover tightly.

Use only dedicated TSP coolers for sandwiches.

Never pack food in a warm cooler. Bring the cooler inside to cool down, and add ice packs to lower the temperature further.

Refrigerator

Clean refrigerator regularly.

Remove all personal food items.

Strictly limit the amount of time the door is open.

When moving sandwiches from fridge to cooler, stay in the shade.

Garage / Collection Area

Keep the collection area clean, uncluttered, and free of strong odors.

Store all food, coolers, and ice packs **off the floor**.

Keep food away from pets, trash, chemicals, and tools.

Food Safety: Shopping and Storage Standards

Use Prepackaged Deli Meat/Cheese Only



Never use products sliced at the deli counter.

Check Expiration Dates



"Use by" date must be **at least 7 days** after drop-off.

Do not overfill your refrigerator.

Allow cold air to circulate around refrigerated foods to keep them properly chilled.

When shopping for ingredients, bring a cooler with ice packs to the store, park in the shade, and place ingredients in coolers for the ride home. Do not make any stops; go straight home.

TSP Accepts Only Unopened Sandwich Ingredients

Sandwich makers with unopened leftover ingredients may drop them off at a host home. We will donate them to groups who would like to make more sandwiches than their budget allows.

Two-Week Maximum

Use all unopened meat/cheese **within 2 weeks of purchase**, regardless of the expiration date.

Discard any meat in an open package.

Food Safety: Labels & Compliance

Label Requirements

Use only TSP-issued labels (may be printed from the TSP app).

After receiving sandwiches, make sure labels match the kind of meat the sandwiches contain.

Fill out all required information.

Time Limits

Sandwiches must be **consumed within 3 days** of the date made (see label).

Spoilage

Bread and sandwich ingredients should appear fresh and free from mold or other spoilage.

Not all spoilage is visible or detectable by smell, so careful handling is essential.

The most important thing to remember is that The Sandwich Project serves our neighbors who are experiencing food insecurity, with a focus on dignity, nourishment, and meeting people where they are.

Additional Transport Safety Tips

- Pre-cool your vehicle before loading coolers
- Plan your route to minimize travel time
- Avoid making stops between pickup and delivery
- Check cooler seals before departing
- Communicate any delays to the recipient organization immediately

Sandwich Maker Guidelines

Preparing Safe, Fresh Sandwiches

As a sandwich maker, you purchase ingredients, prepare sandwiches, and deliver them to a host home. You are responsible for the first several links of the cold chain—from the grocery store through assembly and drop-off.

Shopping for Ingredients

- **Bring a cooler with ice packs to the store.** Park in the shade. Pick up deli items last (remember: the two-hour clock starts the moment they leave the store's refrigerated case). Place them in the cooler for the ride home. Go straight home—no stops.
- **Use only prepackaged deli meat and cheese.** Never use products sliced at the deli counter.
- **Check expiration dates.** Choose products with the furthest dates available. The "use by" date must be at least 7 days after your drop-off date.
- **Buy quality.** Purchase the same quality ingredients you would feed your own family—remember, recipients may be children, elderly, or immunocompromised.
- **Refrigerate immediately upon arriving home.** Meat and cheese go straight into the fridge.

Ingredient Storage Rules

- Two-week maximum: Use all unopened meat/cheese within 2 weeks of purchase, regardless of the expiration date.
- Opened packages: Use within 3 days. Discard any meat in an open package you can't use that quickly.

Don't overfill your refrigerator—air needs room to circulate to keep food properly chilled.

Sandwiches must be made on Wednesday, or Tuesday evening if necessary.

Never make sandwiches before Tuesday evening.

Deliver to your host home within 24 hours of preparation—ideally as soon as possible after making them.

Sandwich-Making Basics

Setting Up Your Workspace

- Clean counters and wash utensils. Cover your work surface with a disposable tablecloth for easy prep and cleanup.
- Tie back hair longer than chin-length or cover it.
- Wash hands with soap and water, then put on food-safe gloves. Change gloves if you touch anything other than food ingredients.

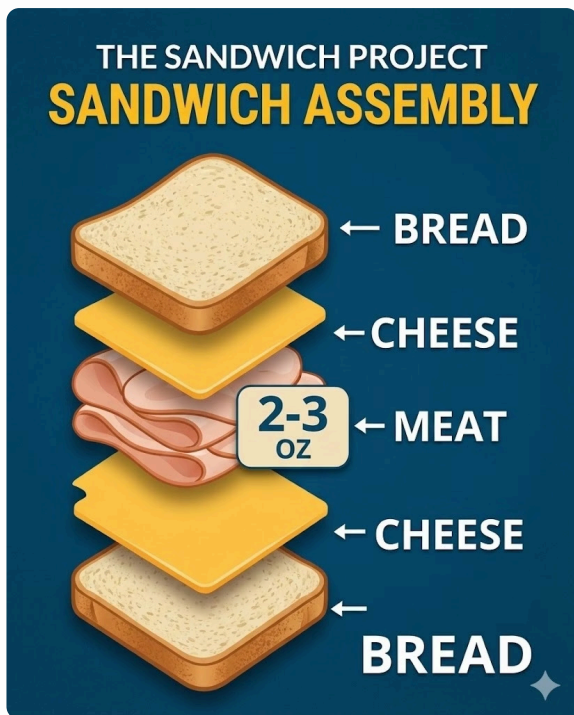
Working in Batches (Maintaining the Cold Chain)

This is where the two-hour rule matters most. Every minute meat spends outside the fridge counts toward that cumulative two-hour limit:

- Take only one package of meat and one package of cheese from the fridge at a time.
- Make one loaf of sandwiches at a time.
- Immediately return the completed loaf to the refrigerator before starting the next.
- If working with a team, divide tasks: some people assemble sandwiches while others pack completed sandwiches, take finished loaves to the refrigerator, and retrieve additional meat/cheese as needed.

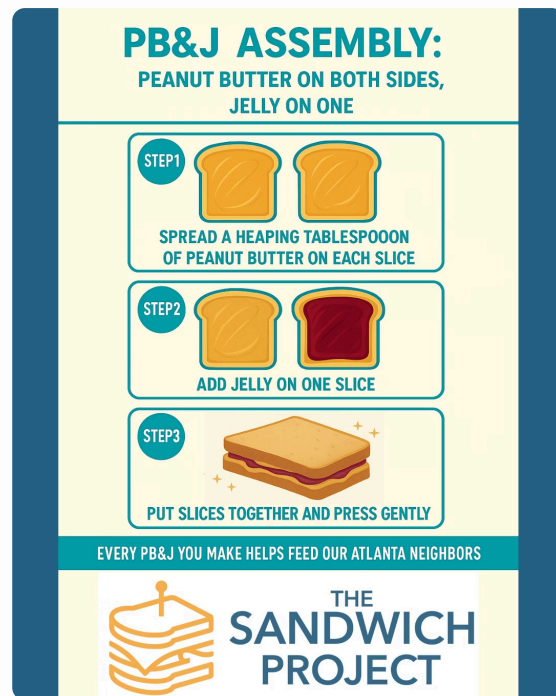
Cross-Contamination Prevention

- Do not leave open containers of peanut butter or nut/shellfish products near deli ingredients.
- Use separate knives for jelly and peanut butter.



PB&J Sandwich Standards

- Spread 1 tablespoon of peanut butter on one side of a slice. Spread 2 tablespoons on the matching side of the other slice.
- Spread 2 teaspoons of jelly (not jam) on top of the peanut butter on one slice.
- Press slices together.
- Place sandwich in an individual sandwich bag. Remove excess air and seal.
- Return bagged sandwich to the bread loaf bag.
- Close loaf bag with a twist tie. Do NOT discard twist ties.



Deli Sandwich Standards

- Use a minimum of 2 ounces of deli meat per sandwich.
- Place 1 slice of cheese on each side of the bread (2 slices total).
- Do NOT add lettuce, tomato, mayo, mustard, or any condiments.
- Place sandwich in an individual sandwich bag. Remove excess air and seal.
- Return bagged sandwich to the bread loaf bag.
- Close loaf bag with a twist tie.

Packaging Your Sandwiches

After Assembling Your Sandwiches

1. Place each finished sandwich into an individual sandwich-size bag.
2. Remove excess air and seal the sandwich bag completely.
3. Return sealed sandwich bags to their original loaf bag.
4. Securely close the loaf bag using the original twist tie.

Sandwiches need to be delivered to a host home within 24 hours of being made.

- It's best to drop them off as soon as possible after preparation.

Transporting Sandwiches to Host Homes

Use Proper Cooling

Use a cooler with ice packs. Fill coolers as much as possible so air does not circulate. Use enough ice packs to keep sandwiches "refrigerator cold."

Never Use Warm Sandwiches

You must never put warm sandwiches into a cooler! Coolers and ice packs do not make sandwiches cold—they only maintain temperature.

Direct Transport

Transport sandwiches directly to a nearby host home.

Use TSP Labels

At the host home, use the correct TSP-issued label: Deli or PB&J.

Remember: Sandwich recipients may be children, elderly, or immunocompromised. When in doubt, throw it out!

Host Guidelines

As a host, you open your home to serve as a central collection point for sandwiches. You are the quality control checkpoint between sandwich makers and drivers—you verify that everything coming in is safe and properly handled, and you make sure everything going out is cold and ready for transport.

Key Responsibilities

- Provide a clean, organized collection area with adequate refrigeration.
- Greet volunteers warmly and help them feel welcome.
- Inspect incoming sandwiches for proper temperature, packaging, and labeling.
- Maintain sign-in sheets and track sandwich counts.
- Prepare coolers and coordinate with drivers for Thursday pickup.
- Report any food safety concerns to TSP leadership.

Materials Provided by TSP

Coolers & Ice Packs

Insulated coolers and reusable ice packs for maintaining temperature during transport.

Collection Site Signage

Signs to help volunteers identify your home as an "official TSP collection location."

Sign-In Sheets

Printed sheets for volunteers to record their names, contact information, and sandwich type and numbers.

TSP Labels

Official labels for volunteers to fill out and attach to their prepared sandwiches (separate PB&J and Deli labels).

Additional Materials:

The Sandwich Project has its own web app! It's easy to get started. Katie will email login information and get you started before your first collection day!

Access at www.thesandwichproject.org (click "Core Team Access")

Anyone with any food allergies should never consume any TSP sandwiches. They are not safe for people with food allergies.

Wednesday: Collection Day Prep

Put Out Donation Bin

Place in an easily accessible location for fruit and/or snack collections.

Prepare Sign-In Station

Place sign-in sheets, both deli & PB&J labels, and pens on a table near the drop-off area.

Organize Sandwich Labels

Keep deli and PB&J labels separate and readily available.

Place TSP Yard Sign

Position prominently for easy site identification by volunteers.

Safe Transportation

Remind volunteers to deliver cold sandwiches in **cooler bags with ice packs** to maintain proper temperature during transport.

Weekly Newsletter

Remind your sandwich makers to sign up for our weekly newsletter: host vacation dates, TSP vacation weeks, and other pertinent information.

Check Labels

Date on labels should be no earlier than **Tuesday evening (preferably Wednesday)**.

Wednesday Protocol: Collection & Storage

Volunteer Arrival

Greet volunteers at your sign-in station. A warm greeting helps sandwich makers feel welcome and want to stay connected.

Sandwich Labeling

Volunteers label their sandwiches using the host's provided labels.

Receive and Inspect Sandwiches

Check that sandwiches are sealed, properly labeled, and cold to the touch.

Volunteers Sign In

Volunteers sign in and record sandwich counts and contact information.

Sandwich Refrigeration

Sandwiches are placed in the refrigerator, with enough room for proper airflow.

Thursday Protocol: Delivery & Transport

Ensure Sandwiches are Pre-Chilled

Ensure sandwiches are under 39°F before placing them in a cooler.

Layer Ice Packs between Sandwiches

Place ice packs between sandwich loaves and on top. All sandwich loaves should be in contact with an ice pack.

Pack Cooler Tightly

Tightly packed coolers stay cold more effectively than those with excess space.

Keep in Vehicle Cabin

Transport coolers inside the vehicle cabin, not the trunk, where air conditioning cannot regulate temperatures.

Deliver Promptly

Take coolers straight to the designated destination without stopping on the way.

Refrigerate Immediately

Transfer sandwiches to a refrigerator as soon as they arrive at their destination.

Important Transport Rules

Never Pack a Hot Cooler

Empty coolers stored in hot conditions must be brought inside to cool completely before packing.

Never Put Warm Sandwiches in a Cooler

Sandwiches must be refrigerator-cold (below 39°F) before going into coolers. This is non-negotiable.

Do Not Leave Coolers in Your Vehicle

Packed coolers must **NEVER be left in vehicles**—only for use during active transport.

TSP Use Only

To prevent cross-contamination, coolers used for TSP sandwiches should not be used for any other purpose.

For example, do not use the same cooler for raw meat, fish, or other items.

Close Lids Tightly and Keep Them Closed

Ensure lids are closed quickly after packing and sealed tightly. Leave them closed—the goal is to have the cooler open for as little time as possible.

Always keep PB&J and Deli in separate coolers.

Anyone with any food allergies should never consume any TSP sandwiches. They are not safe for people with food allergies.

Handling Quality Issues

Open/Torn Bags

Transfer sandwiches to a new bag if the outer bag is torn. Ensure the sandwiches themselves are still properly sealed and intact.

Missing/Incorrect Labels

Ask the volunteer to complete the TSP label. Verify the sandwiches were made in the last 24 hours.

We Cannot Accept Warm/Spoiled/Messy Sandwiches

"Quarantine" Problem Sandwiches

1. Isolate them immediately. Mark the bags clearly with **"DO NOT USE"** and a brief reason (e.g., **"WARM," "OPEN BAG," "UNSAFE"**).
2. Contact your lead host for urgent instructions on disposal.

Quality Check Before Delivery

- Verify all sandwiches are properly sealed
- Confirm TSP labels are complete and legible
- Ensure sandwiches are cold to the touch
- Check that loaf bags are securely closed with twist ties
- Place sandwiches in cooler with adequate ice packs

When to Contact Your Lead Host

- Sandwiches that feel warm or have been left unrefrigerated
- Damaged or improperly sealed packaging
- Missing or incomplete labels
- Any concerns about food safety or quality

Driver Guidelines

As a driver, you are the final link in the cold chain. Your job is to get sandwiches from host homes to recipient organizations quickly, safely, and at the right temperature.

Before Your First Delivery

- **Sign the Vehicle Release Form.** All drivers must complete this before their first delivery. Contact Jordan (Driver Coordinator) at 770-789-7329 if you haven't received one.
- **Understand our delivery partners.** We deliver exclusively to **501(c)(3) organizations**. We cannot hand sandwiches directly to individuals.

Transport Protocol

Pre-cool your vehicle with the A/C before loading. Then:

- Verify sandwiches and coolers are cold before loading. If a cooler feels warm or sandwiches aren't cold to the touch, do not transport them—contact the host or your lead.
- Check that ice packs are layered between loaves and on top, and that coolers are packed tightly with minimal air space.
- Close cooler lids immediately and keep them closed. Do not open coolers during transport.
- Keep coolers in the vehicle cabin where A/C circulates—never in the trunk. Trunks lack airflow and can reach extreme temperatures.
- Drive directly to the delivery location. No stops.
- Transfer sandwiches to a refrigerator immediately upon arrival at the recipient organization.
- Communicate any delays to the recipient organization right away.



Frequently Asked Questions

Food Safety & Best Practices

The following Q&A addresses common questions from our volunteers about food safety, ingredient selection, and best practices.

TEMPERATURE & SAFETY

Q: How can I keep sandwiches safe during preparation?

A: To keep sandwiches safe, get deli meat back into the refrigerator as quickly as possible at each step, and avoid leaving it out longer than necessary.

Q: What is the maximum temperature deli meat can be exposed to?

A: To ensure food safety, deli meat must not be exposed to temperatures exceeding 80°F (27°C).

SHOPPING & STORAGE

Q: Are there special precautions when shopping for TSP?

A: Remember the 2-hour rule, and:

- Take a cooler and ice packs to the store
- Go directly home and refrigerate meat and cheese immediately
- Check expiration dates before you buy meat, cheese, and bread
- Buy the latest expiration date you can find at the store
- Make sure that the date you are dropping off your sandwiches is at least 7 days before the "use by" date on the ingredients

Q: How long can I keep ingredients?

A: Don't use any meat or cheese more than 2 weeks after purchase, even if sealed & unopened and even if the expiration date hasn't passed.

Q: How should I store ingredients in my refrigerator?

A: Don't overpack your refrigerator—air needs to circulate to keep food properly chilled.

Contact Information

TSP Team Contacts:

Driver Coordinator: Jordan | **770-789-7329**

Web App & More: Katie | **770-789-1013**

Executive Director: Christine Cooper Nowicki | **(404) 786-8116**

Safety Committee & Co-Founder | Marcy **(678) 596-9697**

Website: thesandwichproject.org

Email: info@thesandwichproject.org

Your Lead Host:

Name: _____

Phone #: _____

Email: _____